# POST

The PC Build Card Game · CompTIA A+ Core 1 (220-1201) · rules v0.5 for 2 players (3–4 untested)

You're a tech at a small computer shop. A client has handed you a secret **Spec Sheet**. First you race to build a PC that **POSTs**. Then you work **service calls**: install add-ons, finish Tasks, and fix customers' machines. The best-scoring shop wins.

**The game in three lines**
**Phase 1 — the POST race.** Build a PC that POSTs and meets your Spec Sheet's Requirements. The round anyone POSTs is the last round of Phase 1.
**Phase 2 — service calls (5 rounds).** Add parts, claim Tasks, close Trouble Tickets.
**Score.** POST bonus + Benchmark + Spec Sheet + Tasks and Tickets.

## What's in the box

| Deck (card back) | Cards | What's in it | Used in |
|---|---|---|---|
| Spec Sheets (black · gold clipboard) | 9 | Secret client builds | Setup, scoring |
| Motherboards (green · circuit traces) | 13 | 8 desktop, 2 server, 2 laptop, 1 Micro Workstation | Setup |
| Components (blue · chip) | 75 | 12 CPUs, 7 coolers, 28 RAM, 5 Upgrade Kits, 15 drives, 8 PSUs | Phase 1 and 2 |
| Add-ons (purple · monitor) | 58 | 13 expansion cards, 5 RAID, 7 displays, 3 adapters, 8 printers, 10 peripherals, 9 Fixes, 3 Refurb Prebuilts | Phase 2 |
| Tasks (magenta · wrench) | 40 | 26 Tasks and 14 Trouble Tickets | Phase 2 |
| Player aids (slate · ?) | 6 | 3 × Your Turn, 3 × Ready & Score | Reference |

Write-in cards fill out each deck's last sheet. They carry that deck's back, so a new card you design shuffles in invisibly.

## Setup

1. Shuffle each deck separately and set them out by their backs. Leave room for a face-up discard pile next to Components and next to Add-ons.
2. Deal each player **3 Spec Sheets** and **3 Motherboards**.
3. Each player keeps **1 Spec Sheet** face-down and **1 Motherboard that can meet it**. Return the rest to the box. If none of your boards can meet any of your sheets, shuffle the boards back and draw 3 more.
4. Place your board at the far left of your build row.
5. Deal each player **3 Components**.
6. Whoever most recently opened a computer case goes first. Play passes left.

**Which board can meet a sheet?** Some sheets name a board (Server, Laptop, ITX, Micro Workstation, any board with TPM). For the rest, check the Requirements against the board: Content Creator and Virtualization Host need 32 GB+ RAM, so they need a DDR4 or DDR5 desktop board.

### The build row

Lay your build left to right in the order of volatility, motherboard first. **Row 1 — inside the case:** Board · CPU (cooler stacks on it) · RAM · M.2 · RAID · SATA · expansion cards · PSU. **Row 2 — outside the case:** displays (adapters tucked under) · printers · peripherals · media.

## Phase 1: the POST race

Each turn has four steps.

1. **Draw 3 Components, keep 2.** Put the third face-up on the Components discard pile.
2. **Make up to 2 plays.** A play is **Install** a part (a replaced part goes to the discard pile), or **Recycle**: discard up to 3 cards and draw that many Components.
3. **Call POST** if your build is ready (below).
4. **Discard down to 5 cards.**

| Board | Ready to POST needs |
|---|---|
| Desktop or server | Board + CPU + Cooler + RAM + Storage + PSU, all compatible, total ⚡ at or under the PSU's output |
| Laptop (MB-11, MB-12) | Board + RAM + Storage. CPU, cooling and power are built in. |
| Micro Workstation (MB-13) | Board + CPU + RAM + Storage. Cooling and power (external brick) are built in. |
| All boards | **Plus every Requirement on your Spec Sheet.** |

**Upgrade Kits.** A Laptop or Mini PC Upgrade Kit is one card that fills both the RAM and the Storage slot, for 1 play. It only fits the board printed on it. It counts as your RAM and as a drive for everything: Requirements, Tasks, Tickets and Benchmark.

**The audit.** When you call POST, the player on your left checks your build and reads the specs out loud. **No fault:** your build POSTs. **Fault found:** the faulty part is discarded, you don't POST this turn, and the auditor draws 2 Components.

**Finish the round.** Phase 1 ends at the end of the round in which anyone POSTs, so every player gets the same number of turns. Everyone who POSTed in that round earns the **POST bonus: +3**.

## Compatibility

Every requirement is printed on the cards. Special limits are printed on the card they apply to.

| Part | Must match |
|---|---|
| CPU | The board's socket (PGA or LGA). Server boards take 1–2 CPUs of the same tier. |
| Cooler | A rating at or above your CPU's tier. Not used on laptop or Micro boards. |
| RAM | The board's DDR generation and module type (DIMM, SODIMM or ECC RDIMM). One RAM card per build. |
| Storage | One drive per free matching port or slot. Extra drives add to total storage and RAID. |
| Upgrade Kit | The board printed on the kit. Fills RAM + Storage. |
| PSU | Total ⚡ (board + CPU + cooler + expansion cards) at or under the PSU's output. |
| Video card | A free PCIe x16 slot. Its PSU kit raises your PSU limit while installed: at least ⚡9 Entry, ⚡11 Mid, ⚡13 High, ⚡17 Flagship. |
| Other expansion cards | A free slot of the same size or bigger. PCI cards need a PCI slot. |
| RAID | At least its minimum number of drives installed. |
| Displays | A free video output matching an input. An adapter bridges a mismatch; attaching one is free. |
| Printers, peripherals | 1 USB port each. Networked printers use none. Docks add ports (laptops only). |

## Phase 2: service calls

Phase 2 lasts **5 rounds**. At the start, each player draws **3 Task cards** and lays them face-up in front of them. Your Tasks are yours alone. Each turn has five steps.

1. **Draw 1 Task card.**
2. **Draw 3, keep 2,** from either Components or Add-ons. Choose the deck before you draw. The third goes on that deck's discard pile.
3. **Make up to 2 plays:** install a part or add-on · close a Trouble Ticket · recycle (discard up to 3, draw that many from either deck).
4. **Claim every Task your build now meets.** Free, no limit. Your build must be ONLINE.
5. **Discard down to 5 cards.**

**ONLINE** means your build POSTed and still meets the Ready-to-POST list. **Free on your turn:** attach an adapter under a display.

**Still haven't POSTed?** Keep taking Phase 1 turns, drawing from Components only. Before you draw, you may take any 1 card from the Components discard pile. You can still POST and score your Spec Sheet, but you don't earn the POST bonus.

### Trouble Tickets

A Trouble Ticket is a customer's broken machine — your own build never goes down. To close one, your build must be ONLINE (you need a working bench). Closing costs 1 play: discard a card that fixes it along with the ticket, and keep the ticket for points.

| Close it with | Points |
|---|---|
| The right Fix card, or a replacement part of the right kind | 2 |
| A Refurb Prebuilt (internal hardware only — you swapped the system but never found the fault) | 1 |

| Trouble Ticket | Right Fix | Or replace with | Prebuilt? |
|---|---|---|---|
| Overheating (×2) | Thermal Paste & Pads | Any cooler | Yes |
| POST Beeps | Reseat RAM | Any RAM | Yes |
| Capacitor Swelling | — | — | Yes — the only fix |
| Wrong Date & Time | CMOS Battery | — | Yes |
| S.M.A.R.T. Failure | — | Any drive | Yes |
| Grinding & Clicking | — | Any drive | Yes |
| Bootable Device Not Found | Fix Boot Order | Any drive | Yes |
| Burning Smell | — | Any PSU | Yes |
| Swollen Battery | Replace Battery | — | Refurb Laptop only |
| Screen Burn-In | — | Any display | No |
| Paper Jam | Printer Maintenance | Any printer | No |
| External Interference | Wi-Fi Analyzer | — | No |
| Intermittent Connectivity | Cable Tester | 10 GbE Fiber NIC | No |

The “No” rows are the lesson: a new PC doesn't fix a monitor, a printer or the airwaves.

## Game end and scoring

The game ends after round 5 of Phase 2. Everyone checks every build together — the **final audit** — and removes any faulty part. Then score:

| Category | How it scores |
|---|---|
| POST bonus | +3 if you POSTed in the round Phase 1 ended. |
| Benchmark | ONLINE builds only. Add the ★ of your CPU, RAM, best drive and best video card. RAID 0 or 10 adds +1 to the drive (max 5). A laptop's built-in CPU scores its printed tier. An Upgrade Kit scores its RAM ★ and its drive ★. |
| Spec Sheet | The sheet's value plus each Bonus you have — if you POSTed meeting every Requirement and your build is still ONLINE. Otherwise 0. |
| Tasks and Tickets | The points on each one you claimed or closed. |

Highest total wins. Tie: the higher Benchmark wins.

### The Spec Sheets

Requirements are parts inside the case, because you need them to POST. Bonuses are what you chase in Phase 2. Harder, slower builds are worth more.

| Spec Sheet | Value | Requirements (to POST) | Bonuses |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Gaming Rig** | 6 | 16 GB+ RAM · CPU Tier 3+ | Video card Tier 3+ +3 · Display 144 Hz or faster +2 · NVMe drive +1 · USB headset +1 |
| **Office Workstation** | 5 | Board with TPM · Any SSD | Laser printer or Laser MFD +2 · Two displays +2 · Webcam + USB headset +1 |
| **File Server** | 6 | Server board · ECC RAM · 2 or more drives | RAID 1, 5, 6 or 10 +3 · Redundant PSU +2 · Two CPUs +2 · 10 GbE Fiber NIC +2 |
| **Virtualization Host** | 8 | 8+ core CPU with virtualization · 32 GB+ RAM | ECC RAM +2 · Any RAID +1 · 10 GbE Fiber NIC +2 |
| **Road Warrior** | 6 | Laptop board · M.2 or mSATA SSD · 8 GB+ RAM | Docking station +2 · Fingerprint login +1 · USB headset +1 |
| **Home Theater PC** | 6 | ITX board · 4 TB+ total storage | OLED, VA or Mini-LED display +2 · Desktop speakers +2 · Optical drive +1 · PSU 450 W or less +1 |
| **Content Creator** | 8 | 32 GB+ RAM · 8 TB+ total storage | Capture card +3 · IPS or OLED display +2 · Drawing pad +1 · Webcam + USB headset +1 |
| **Retail Counter** | 4 | Board with TPM | Thermal printer +2 · Fingerprint reader +2 · Impact printer +1 · Laser MFD +1 |
| **Micro Workstation** | 6 | Micro Workstation board · Any SSD | Two displays +2 · Webcam + USB headset +1 · NVMe drive +1 |

## Variants

- **First game:** Spec Sheets face-up, no audits, and you may ask “Would this fit?” before installing.
- **Class period:** play Phase 2 for 3 rounds instead of 5.
- **Hard mode:** before you claim a Task, the player on your left covers its NEEDS line and you name the parts that meet it.
- **Help Desk teams:** pairs share one build and one hand and must agree out loud on every play.
- **3–4 players (untested):** Phase 2 lasts 4 rounds.

## Printing the test deck (cut-and-stack)

The card file is imposed for **cut-and-stack**: you cut every sheet in one pass, and the six piles stack into a sorted deck. No sorting after cutting.

1. Open **POST_Cards_v0.5_duplex.pdf**. Every front sheet is followed by its back sheet.
2. Print on letter cardstock at **100% / Actual size** (not “Fit”), **double-sided, flip on long edge**.
3. Print pages 1–2 first and hold the sheet to a light: the crop marks on both sides should line up. If the backs are upside down, switch to “flip on short edge.”
4. Print the rest. Arrange the stack so **stack sheet 1 is on top, fronts up**, and the sheets run in order to sheet 36. The sheet number is printed at the top-left of each front.
5. Jog the stack square and cut all 36 sheets at once on the grey crop lines.
6. Each position becomes a pile; its letter is printed in the margin (PILE A … PILE F). Keep each pile in its cut order. Put **pile A on top of pile B**, that on C, and so on down to F.
7. Read from the top, the cards now run #1 to #216 in deck order. Split the decks where the card back changes.

| Pile | Cards | Contains |
|---|---|---|
| A | #1–36 | Spec Sheets, Motherboards, first Components |
| B | #37–72 | Components |
| C | #73–108 | Components |
| D | #109–144 | Add-ons |
| E | #145–180 | Add-ons, first Tasks |
| F | #181–216 | Tasks, Player aids |

Cards are 2.75 × 4.75 in (tarot). The side margins are only 0.125 in; if your printer clips the outer cards, print at 97% and trim. Each deck ends with its own write-in cards. **POST_Cards_v0.5_fronts_only.pdf** has the same sheets, fronts only, for proofing.

## What changed from v0.4

- The Market is gone. You draw 3 and keep 2 from separate decks, each with its own back.
- Two phases: the POST race, then 5 rounds of service calls.
- Hazards are now **Trouble Tickets** in the Tasks deck: customers' machines, not attacks on your build. Fixes and Refurb Prebuilts close them.
- Prebuilts are no longer boards. They close internal-hardware tickets for 1 point.
- Spec Sheet Requirements are inside-the-case parts and must be met to POST. A failed sheet scores 0, not −3.
- **New:** 5 Upgrade Kits (RAM + drive in one card), the MB-13 Micro Workstation board and its Spec Sheet.
- Rebalanced values: File Server 6 (now needs 2+ drives), Virtualization Host 8, Road Warrior 6, Micro Workstation 6.
- Video cards include a PSU kit, so they no longer need a separate PSU upgrade.
- Cards are tarot size (2.75 × 4.75 in).

## Playtest notes

In 400-game simulations per sheet, every Spec Sheet now wins 49–57% of games against a freely chosen opponent sheet. The bots don't bluff or plan ahead, so watch for these at the table:

- **Minutes per round** in each phase. The sim expects about 5 rounds of Phase 1 and 5 of Phase 2.

- **Is the race too decisive?** If the player who POSTs second rarely wins, try a 6th round of Phase 2.
- **Do Upgrade Kits make laptops too fast?** Road Warrior POSTs around round 3–4 in the sim.
- **Recycling:** does it feel like play or busywork? Bots recycle about 6 times a game.
- **Trouble Tickets:** do players reason about the symptom, or just match names?
- **Dead cards:** note any card that sat in a hand for 3+ turns.

| Game | Players / sheets | POST rounds | Phase 2 rounds | Minutes | Final scores | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | | | | |
| 2 | | | | | | |
| 3 | | | | | | |